Content audit template

A URL inventory with Search Console and GA4 data, a quality score on 5 criteria and one decision for every page. Version: November 2026.

Website (URL) _____ Audit date _____

Audit owner _____ Next review _____

How to use this template

1. **Set the scope** in part 1: site sections, date range and who signs off on removing pages.
2. **List every URL** in part 2: sitemap, CMS export or crawl, plus the Pages tab in Search Console. Each URL once.
3. **Add the data** from Search Console (clicks, year-over-year change, average position, indexing, links), GA4 (key events) and your CMS (words, update date).
4. **Score quality** in part 3: five criteria, 0–2 points each. The scoring key is above the table.
5. **Enter one decision** using a code from the legend below. For merges and redirects, add the target URL. Give every decision an owner and a due date.
6. **Log redirects** in part 5 and check each one after it goes live.
7. **Measure the effect** in part 6 at 30 and 90 days. Repeat the review every quarter for content older than 12 months.

Part 1. Audit scope and thresholds

Sections in scope (e.g. blog, service pages, guides) _____

Clicks: last 12 months, from – to _____

Year-over-year change: last 3 months vs the same months a year earlier, dates _____

Who signs off on removing and merging pages _____

Pages we never remove without approval (e.g. service pages, terms) _____

Thresholds to flag (adjust to your site)

- ☐ Average position 4–20 for a keyword that matters to sales: update candidate.
- ☐ Clicks down year over year: rule out seasonality, then update.
- ☐ Last substantial update more than 12 months ago: freshness review.
- ☐ Fewer than 250 words in the HTML: check whether the text only loads with JavaScript.
- ☐ Two pages with the same primary keyword: cannibalization, merge or split the intent.
- ☐ Your own threshold: _____

Decision codes

KEEP	keep as is	301	merge into another URL (301 redirect)
UPD	update: data, title, links	NI	noindex, remove from the sitemap
EXP	expand: section, FAQ, example	DEL	remove (404/410) when no related page exists

Order: improve first, merge second, remove last. Pages with external links or leads are never removed without a 301 redirect.

Part 2. Inventory and data

One row = one URL. Type: S – service, A – article, G – guide, C – category, O – other. Indexing: I – indexed, or a short form of the status from the Page indexing report (e.g. "crawled, not indexed", "duplicate", "soft 404"). Carry the row number (No.) over to part 3.

NO.	URL	TYPE	PRIMARY KEYWORD	CLICKS 12 MO.	YOY CHANGE	AVG. POS.	INDEXING	EXT. LINKS	KEY EVENTS	WORDS	LAST UPDATE
1											
2											
3											
4											
5											
6											
7											
8											
9											
10											
11											
12											
13											
14											
15											
16											
17											
18											
19											
20											
21											
22											
23											
24											

Sources: Search Console (Performance report, Pages tab; Page indexing report; Links report, Top linked pages), GA4 (key events from sessions that started on the page), CMS or crawler (word count, date of the last substantial update). Search Console keeps data for the last 16 months.

Parts 3 and 4. Quality score and decision

Criteria C1–C5 from the key below: score each 0, 1 or 2. Total 8–10: usually keep; 5–7: update or expand; 0–4: rewrite, merge or remove. Make the final call together with the part 2 data: traffic, links and leads matter more than the score alone.

CRITERION	2 POINTS	1 POINT	0 POINTS
C1 · Intent	Format and depth match the Google top 10 for the keyword	Right topic, wrong format	Answers a different question
C2 · Freshness	Prices, rules, data and screenshots current	Minor outdated details	Wrong or outdated information
C3 · Added value	Own data, examples, experience	Accurate, but like other pages	A summary of other people's content
C4 · Trust	Author, date and sources for figures	One of these missing	No author, date or sources
C5 · Structure and links	Question headings answered directly, links to a service page and 2–4 pieces	Partly	A wall of text, no links

NO.	C1	C2	C3	C4	C5	TOTAL	DECISION CODE	WHAT TO DO · 301 TARGET URL	OWNER	DUE	DONE
1											☐
2											☐
3											☐
4											☐
5											☐
6											☐
7											☐
8											☐
9											☐
10											☐
11											☐
12											☐
13											☐
14											☐
15											☐
16											☐
17											☐
18											☐
19											☐
20											☐
21											☐
22											☐
23											☐
24											☐

Decision criteria

DECISION	WHEN (DATA AND SCORE)	WHAT TO DO
KEEP	Clicks stable or growing year over year, score 8–10	Change nothing. Google advises against changing content that is already performing well. Just check the link to the service page.
UPD · update	Average position 4–20 for a keyword with potential, or clicks down year over year, score 5–7	Refresh data and examples, add missing subtopics from the search results, improve the title, add internal links. Change the date only after a substantial change.
EXP · expand	The page shows up for queries it does not answer, or covers an important topic too thinly	Add a section, an FAQ or an example. If the text is added by JavaScript, switch on server-side rendering.
301 · merge	Two or more pages on the same topic or keyword, each weak on its own	Keep the stronger URL, move the unique parts over, 301 the weaker URLs, fix internal links and the sitemap.
NI · noindex	Users need the page, but it has no value in search results (e.g. a thank-you page)	Add a robots noindex meta tag, remove the URL from the sitemap. Do not block it in robots.txt, or crawlers will never see the noindex.
DEL · 404/410	No traffic, external links, leads or business value, the content cannot be saved, score 0–4	If a closely related page exists, 301 to it (not to the home page). If not, use 404 or 410: Google treats them the same. Remove internal links and the sitemap entry.

The position range (4–20) and content age (12 months) are working rules, not Google requirements. Google has no preferred word count, so a short page that answers the question stays.

Part 5. Redirect map

List every redirect from 301 decisions and from DEL decisions with a related page. The new URL must cover the same topic and return a 200 status, with no redirect chain.

NO.	OLD URL	NEW URL	CODE	INTERNAL LINKS FIXED	REMOVED FROM SITEMAP	CHECKED (DATE)
1				☐	☐	
2				☐	☐	
3				☐	☐	
4				☐	☐	
5				☐	☐	
6				☐	☐	
7				☐	☐	
8				☐	☐	
9				☐	☐	
10				☐	☐	
11				☐	☐	
12				☐	☐	

Part 6. Measurement at 30 and 90 days

In Search Console, filter by page (for a merge, use the target URL) and compare periods of the same length before and after the change. Do not judge changes after one week: Google says some take effect in a few days, but reassessing the whole site can take several months.

URL	DECISION CODE	DATE LIVE	CLICKS 30 DAYS BEFORE	CLICKS 30 DAYS AFTER	CLICKS 90 DAYS AFTER	AVG. POS. BEFORE	AVG. POS. AT 90 DAYS	TAKEAWAY

Quarterly review

1. Which changes brought the most clicks and leads after 90 days?

2. Which had no effect, and what is the decision now?

3. Do two URLs still show up for the same keyword?

4. Do AI Overviews and AI assistants cite the pages we updated?

Checklist before you close the audit

- ☐ Every URL from the sitemap and the Search Console Pages tab is in the inventory.
- ☐ Every page has one primary keyword, and no two pages target the same one.
- ☐ Pages with external links or leads are never removed without a 301 redirect.
- ☐ No redirect points to the home page instead of a closely related page.
- ☐ Noindexed pages are not blocked in robots.txt and are not in the sitemap.
- ☐ Internal links point straight to the new URLs, with no redirect chains.
- ☐ The "updated" date changed only where the content really changed.
- ☐ The next review date is in the team calendar.